Hyperspectral Remote Sensing

IRS Chapter 14.1-14.10

John C. Femiani
CSE 620B | Miami University

Sections

1. **Foundations** (14.1-14.4): spectroscopy, calibration, and AVIRIS
2. **Image cubes and abundance mapping** (14.5-14.7): libraries, noise reduction, and endmembers
3. **Advanced analysis** (14.8-14.10): mixtures, spectral matching, and interpretation

Section 1 | Chapter 14.1-14.4

Foundations

Spectroscopy, calibration, and hyperspectral sensors

Introduction to Hyperspectral Remote Sensing

Narrow bands connect remote sensing to spectroscopy. We first examine calibration and AVIRIS, then move to image cubes, libraries, and unmixing.

- **Hyperspectral** vs. conventional remote sensing
- Uses **many narrow spectral channels** (often 200+)
- Channels as narrow as **10 nm**
- Enables **fine spectral resolution**

Spectroscopy and Hyperspectral Data

- **Spectroscopy** enhances material identification
- Uses **detailed spectral data** for analysis
- Enables **matching spectra to libraries**
- Supports atmospheric correction using information within the image

Origins of Spectroscopy

- **Isaac Newton**: Separated light with prisms
- **William Wollaston**: Observed dark lines in spectra
- **Joseph Fraunhofer**: Identified solar absorption lines
- **Niels Bohr**: Linked spectral lines to atomic structure

Instruments in Spectroscopy

- **Spectroscope**: Basic instrument for viewing spectra
- **Spectrometer**: Measures light intensity at each wavelength
- **Spectrograph**: Records spectra over a range of wavelengths

Hyperspectral Imaging Applications

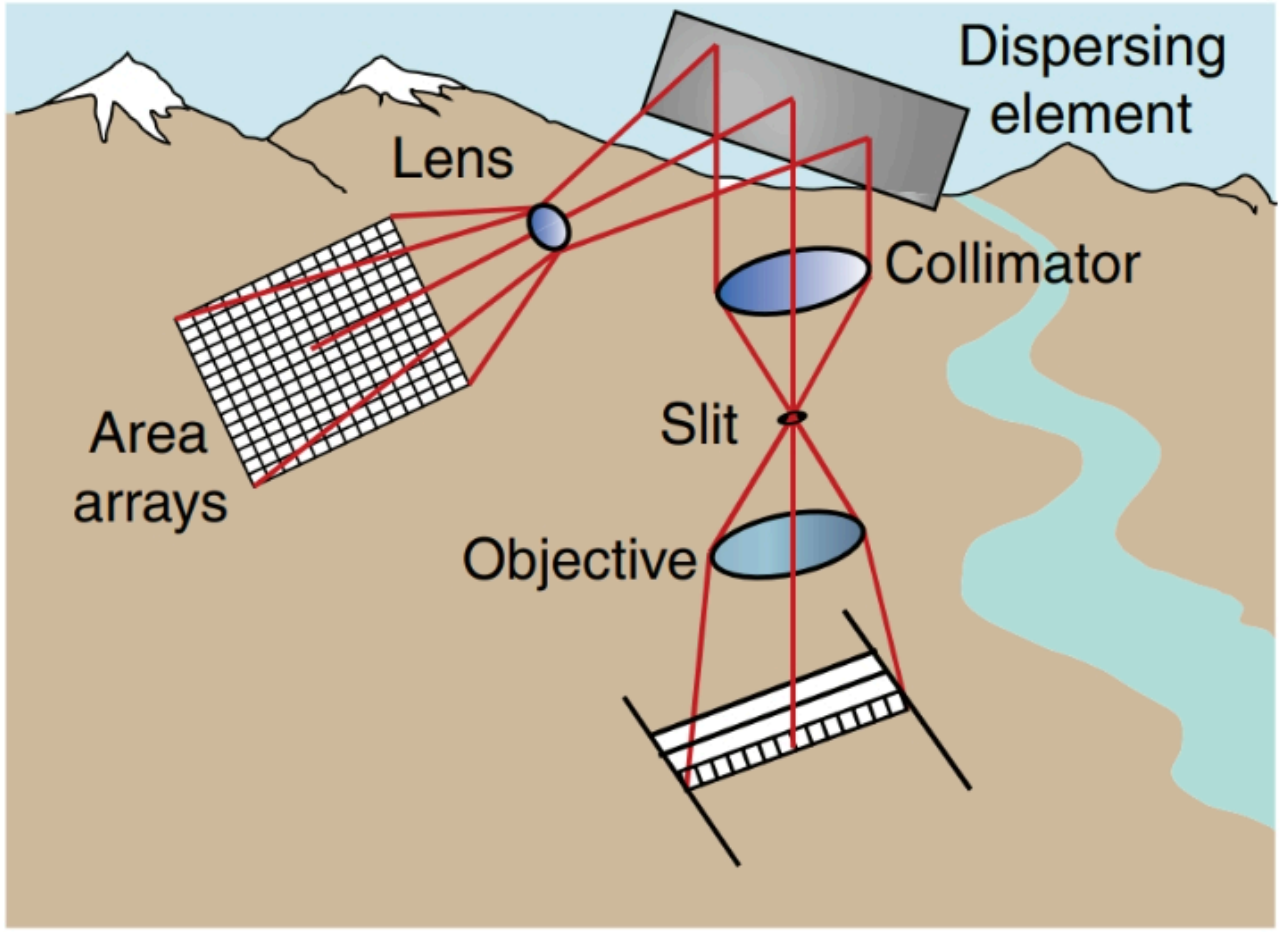
- Focuses on **identifying materials** through spectral signatures
- Extends beyond visible wavelengths to **NIR and SWIR**
- Used for **Earth surface analysis** and atmospheric correction

Importance of Calibration

- Calibration **ensures data accuracy** across channels
- Essential for **consistent spectral measurements**
- Addresses **instrument and environmental variability**

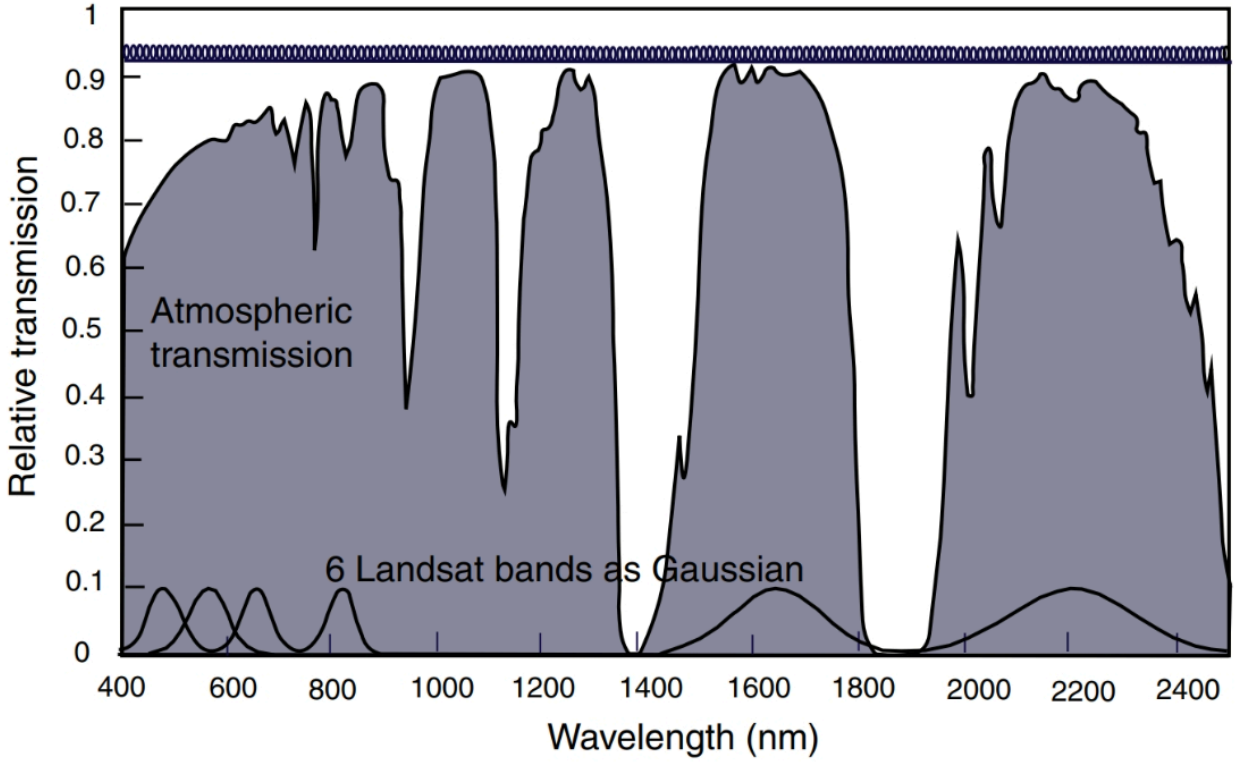
AVIRIS: A Key Hyperspectral Instrument

- Developed by **NASA/JPL** in the 1980s
- Collects **224 channels** across 400-2500 nm
- Enables **high-resolution hyperspectral imaging**



AVIRIS Spectral and Spatial Range

- Spectral range: **400-2500 nm**
- Channel width: approximately **10 nm**
- Spatial resolution varies by altitude:
  - High altitude: approximately **20 m** per pixel



Hyperspectral Data and Material Analysis

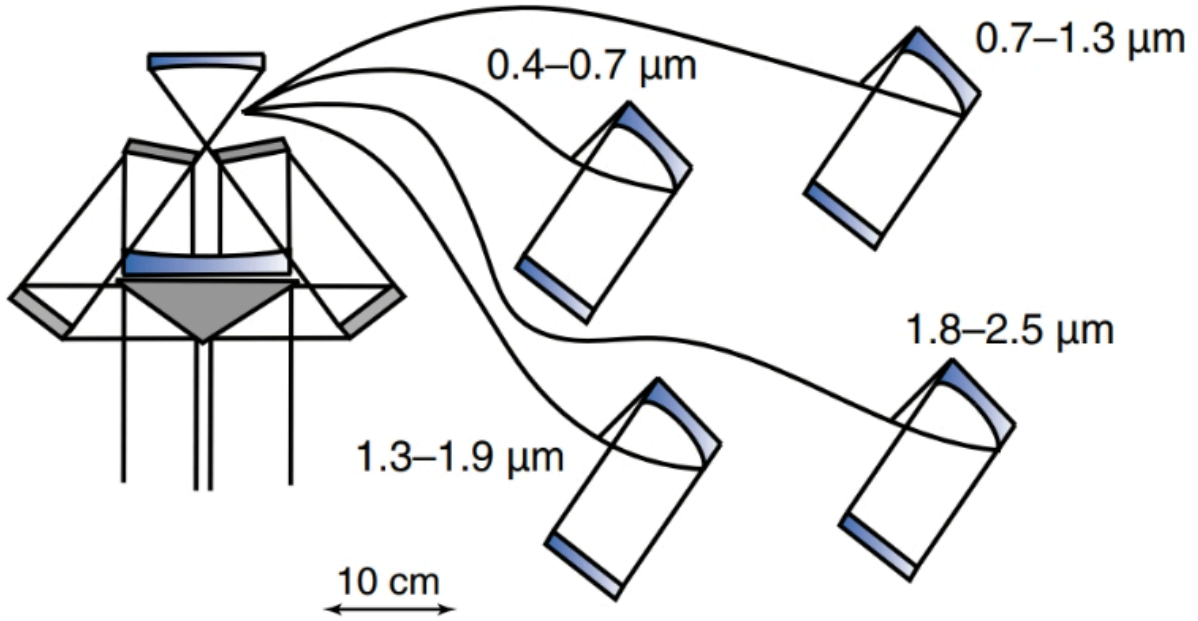
- Enables **precise material matching** to spectral libraries
- Common in **mineralogy, agriculture, and environmental studies**
- Can support correction for **atmospheric effects**

Classical Spectroscopy vs. Hyperspectral Imaging

- **Classical spectroscopy**: Analyzes single-point targets
- **Hyperspectral imaging**: Captures extensive spatial areas
- Applied to **large surface areas** rather than isolated points

Components of Hyperspectral Sensors

- **Diffraction grating**: Separates light into spectral bands
- **Detector arrays**: Capture visible, NIR, and SWIR ranges
- Fine **spectral, spatial, and radiometric resolution**



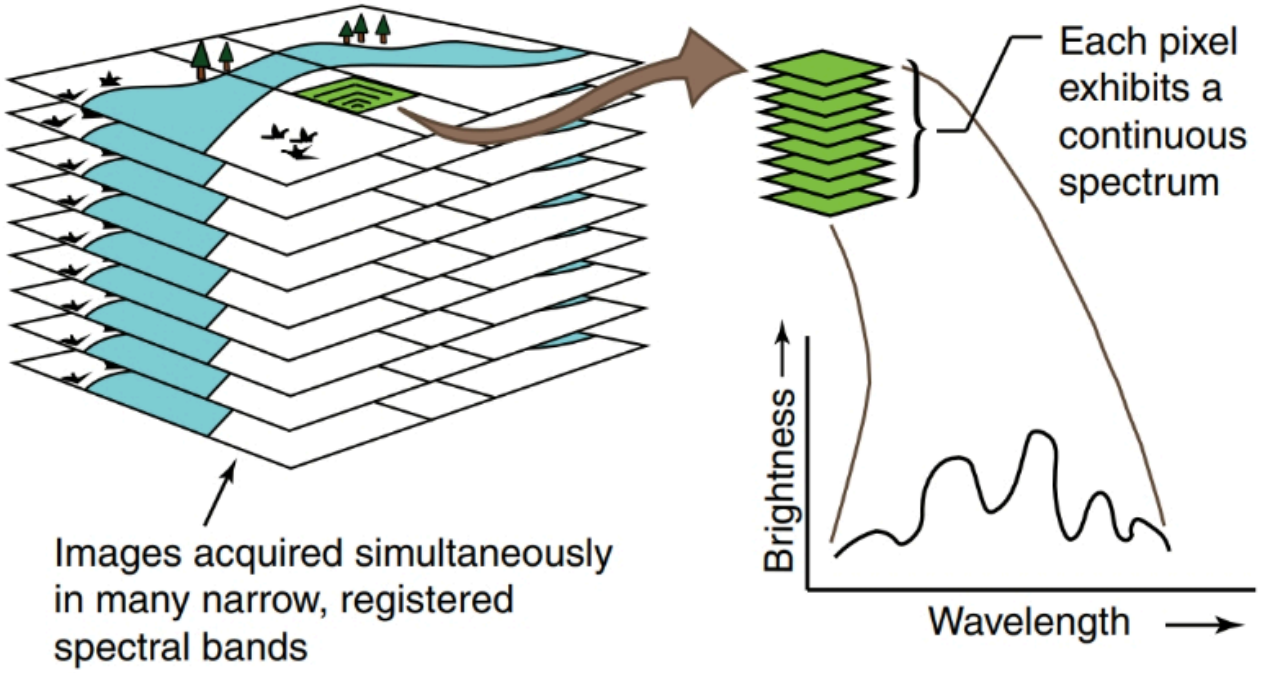
Section 2 | Chapter 14.5-14.7

Image Cubes and Abundance Mapping

Spectral libraries, noise reduction, and endmembers

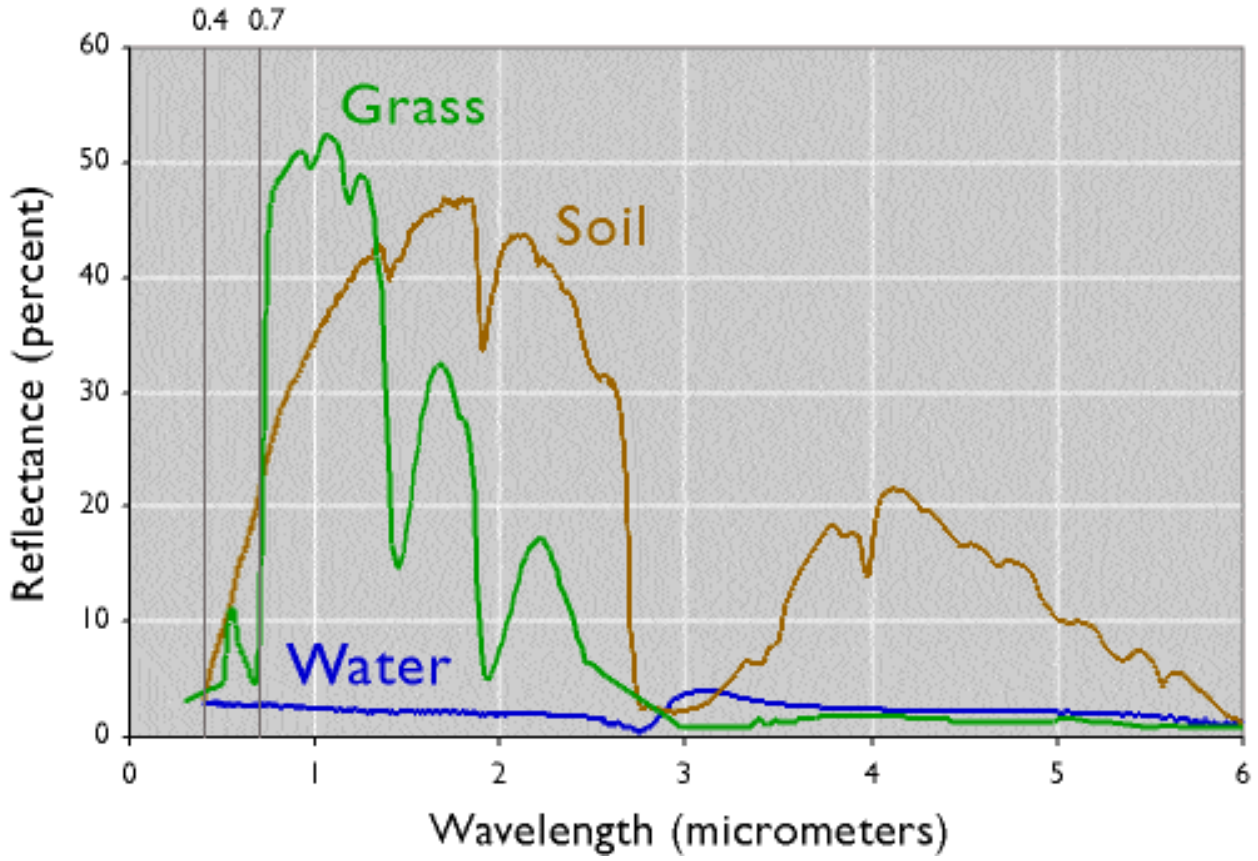
The Hyperspectral Image Cube

- **Image cube**: 3D structure in hyperspectral data
- **X, Y**: Spatial dimensions (map)
- **Z**: Stacked spectral bands (wavelengths)
- Captures **spectral profile for each pixel**



Understanding Spectral Libraries

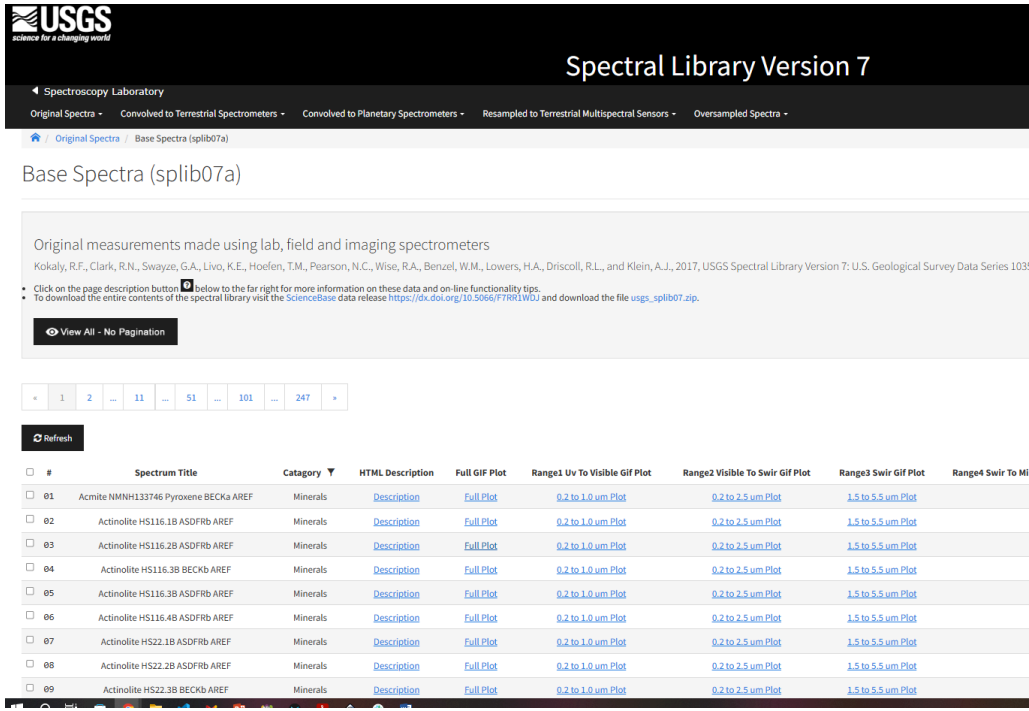
- **Spectral libraries**: Reference databases for spectral analysis
- Store spectra from **lab and field conditions**
- Data from **minerals, vegetation, materials**, etc.
- Essential for **material identification**



Data Sources for Spectral Libraries

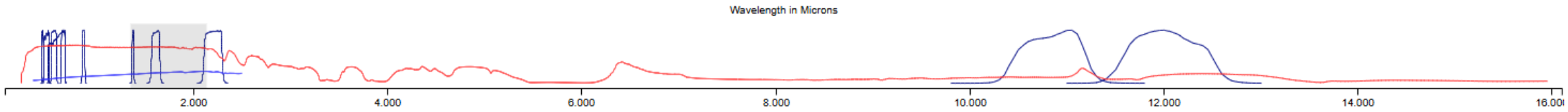
- Data from **laboratory** and **field measurements**
- Includes **minerals, vegetation, materials**, etc.
- Acquired under **controlled and natural conditions**
- Represent **varied terrain and climates**

Libraries compile spectra from diverse sources to support hyperspectral analysis.



Standardization in Spectral Libraries

- **Standardization** enables consistent use across applications
- Spectra must be comparable despite **instrument and condition differences**
- Records include **instrument details, conditions, and surface characteristics**

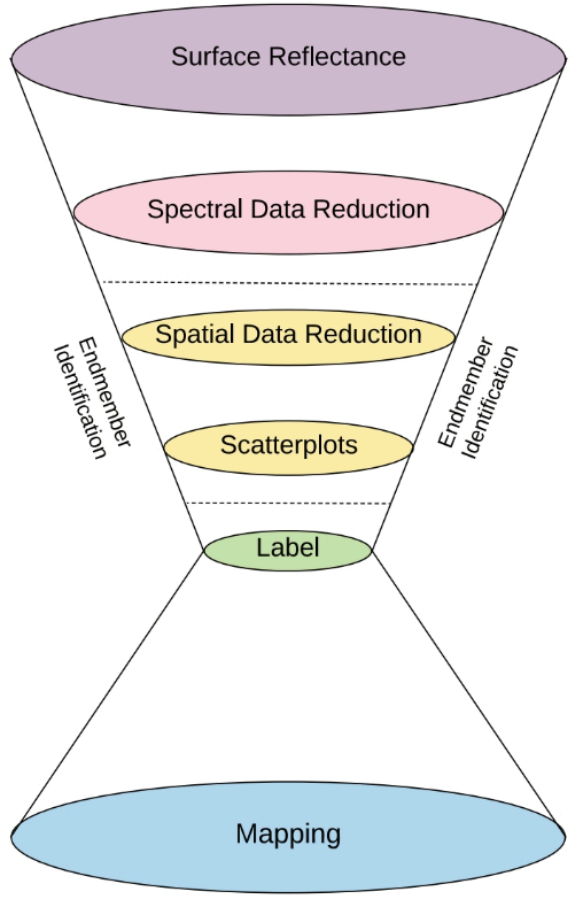


Landsat 9 sensor bands (blue) and asphalt spectrum (red).
https://landsat.usgs.gov/spectral-characteristics-viewer

From Spectra to Abundances

The next three slides explain MNF, endmembers, and unmixing. Surface reflectance is a prerequisite from Chapter 11.

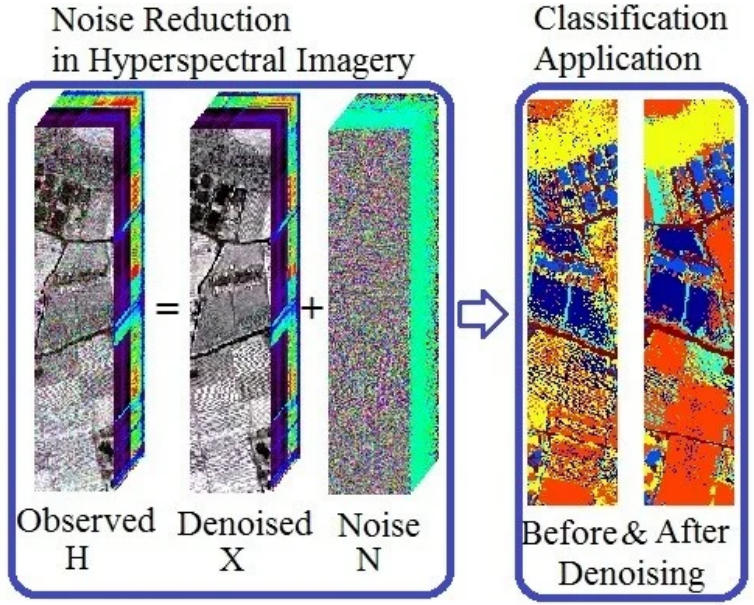
1. Start with atmospherically corrected surface reflectance.
2. Reduce noise dimensions using retained MNF components.
3. Select or estimate representative material spectra (endmembers).
4. Fit material fractions and inspect reconstruction residuals.

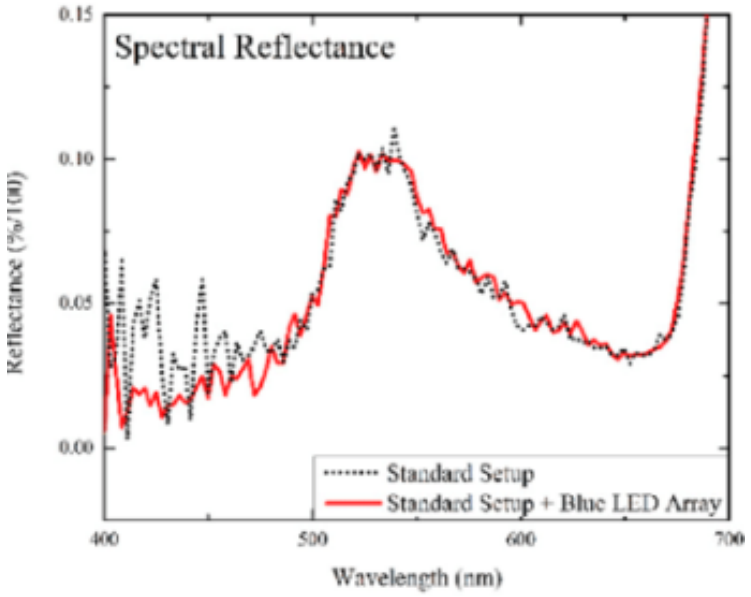


Maximum Noise Fraction (MNF)

- **Purpose**: Improve signal-to-noise by discarding noise-dominated components
- **Key steps**:
  i. Estimate noise statistics from sensor data or homogeneous regions.
  ii. Whiten estimated noise: transform its covariance to the identity. This does not remove noise.
  iii. Apply PCA: order transformed components by signal-to-noise.
- Analysts choose how many components to retain for material mapping.

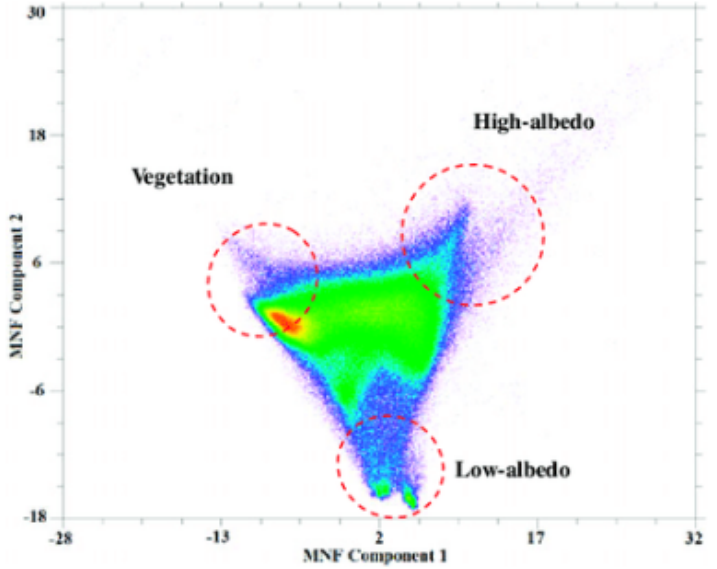
MNF is a noise-aware extension of PCA.

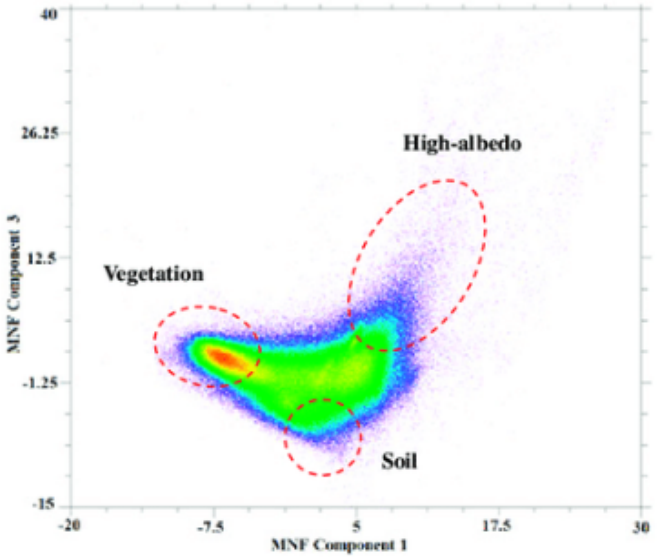




Pure Pixels and Spectral Endmembers

- A **scatter plot** projects each pixel into a feature space.
- **Endmembers**: spectra representing the materials used to explain scene pixels
- Pure pixels are useful candidates, but may not exist at the sensor's spatial resolution.
- Endmembers can also be estimated geometrically or statistically.
- Use libraries and field knowledge to interpret candidates; geometry alone does not name a material.





Linear Spectral (Un)mixing

- **Purpose**: Estimate material proportions in mixed pixels
- **Fraction vector $\mathbf{f}$**: proportions of each material
- Fully constrained fractions are **nonnegative** and **sum to 1**.

$$\mathbf{x} = \sum_{j=1}^{N} f_j \mathbf{m}_j = \mathbf{M}\mathbf{f}$$

$$f_j \geq 0, \qquad \sum_j f_j = 1$$

Columns of $\mathbf{M}$ are endmember spectra. We revisit this model with a residual term in Section 3.

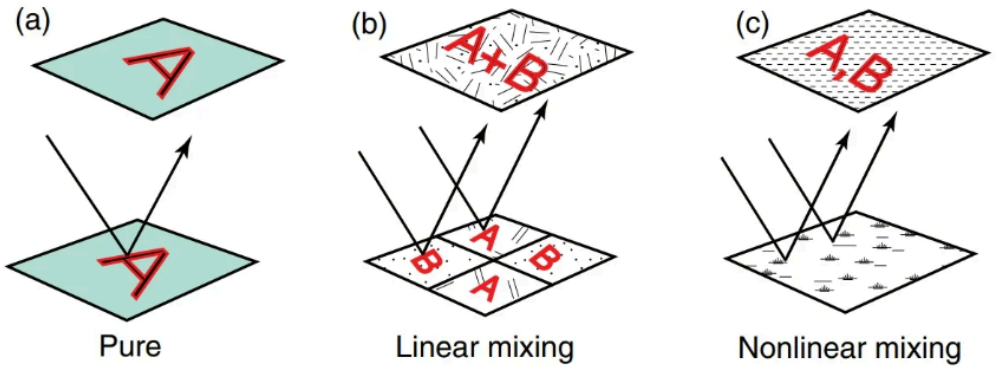


TABLE 14.1 Example of Mixture of Two Endmembers

	Water	Trees	Riparian
Blue	1014.0	941.0	962.9
Red	832.0	799.0	808.9
Green	538.0	579.0	566.7
NIR	338.0	1846.0	1393.6

Section 3 | Chapter 14.8-14.10

Advanced Analysis

Endmembers, mixtures, and spectral matching

The Question Behind Unmixing

At 20 m spatial resolution, one pixel may cover several materials.

Next: endmember geometry, a numerical mixture, the limits of linear mixing, and spectral-angle matching.

- Classification asks: which label best describes this pixel?
- Unmixing asks: what material fractions could explain its spectrum?
- Both depend on preprocessing, endmember choice, and model assumptions.

Endmembers and Convex Geometry

- Represent each pixel as a point in a space with one axis per band.
- Under a linear mixture, pixel spectra lie inside the convex hull of the endmembers.
- Affinely independent endmembers form the vertices of a simplex: a line segment, triangle, or higher-dimensional analogue.
- Pure pixels are convenient vertices, not a requirement; algorithms can estimate vertices when no pure pixel is present.

Linear Mixing Model: Including Residuals

Revisiting Section 2, the reflectance in each band is modeled as a weighted sum plus residual error:

$$\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{M}\mathbf{f} + \boldsymbol{\epsilon}, \qquad f_j \geq 0, \qquad \sum_j f_j = 1$$

- $\mathbf{x}$: observed spectrum
- Columns of $\mathbf{M}$: selected endmember spectra
- $\mathbf{f}$: estimated fractions; $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}$: residual error

The constraints describe the fully constrained model; they are assumptions, not proof of a good fit.

A Small Mixture Example

Suppose a three-band pixel is a mixture of vegetation and soil:

$$\mathbf{m}_{veg} = [0.05, 0.10, 0.50]^T, \qquad \mathbf{m}_{soil} = [0.20, 0.25, 0.30]^T$$

With fractions $\mathbf{f} = [0.7, 0.3]^T$:

$$\mathbf{x} = 0.7\mathbf{m}_{veg} + 0.3\mathbf{m}_{soil} = [0.095, 0.145, 0.440]^T$$

The estimate is only as meaningful as the endmembers and mixing model.

When Linear Mixing Breaks Down

- Linear mixing models side-by-side materials as an additive weighted sum, without material-to-material scattering interactions.
- Multiple scattering, intimate mineral mixtures, and layered canopies can violate that assumption.
- A structured residual is evidence to inspect, not a reason to add complexity automatically.
- Nonlinear models can represent interactions, but require additional assumptions or calibration data.

Spectral Angle Mapping

Compare a pixel spectrum with a reference spectrum by the angle between their vectors:

$$\theta = \cos^{-1}\left(\frac{\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{r}}{\|\mathbf{x}\|_2\,\|\mathbf{r}\|_2}\right)$$

- Smaller angles indicate more similar spectral shape.
- Positive rescaling does not change the angle, so brightness differences matter less.
- SAM returns similarity to a reference; it does not estimate mixture fractions.

Match, Classify, or Unmix?

Goal	Useful starting point	Main limitation
Match known material spectra	Spectral angle or library matching	Reference and scene conditions may differ
Assign one label per pixel	Supervised classification	Hides within-pixel mixtures
Estimate material proportions	Constrained unmixing	Depends on endmembers and mixing assumptions

Use the question and available reference data to choose the method.

Review: Putting the Analysis Together

1. Confirm wavelength calibration, bad-band handling, and reflectance units.
2. Reduce noise and inspect retained MNF components.
3. Select or estimate candidate endmembers; record their provenance.
4. Fit fractions or compare reference spectra.
5. Inspect residuals and spatial patterns before interpreting the map.

Multiscale Features and Learned Models

- Wavelets describe local spectral detail at different wavelength scales: broad continuum shape versus narrow absorption structure.
- The transform alone does not identify a material or correct the atmosphere; discarding coefficients also discards information.
- A supervised model such as an SVM can learn nonlinear decision boundaries from labeled spectra.
- A nonlinear classifier is not automatically a physical unmixing model; validate its predictions on independent samples.

Notebook: Fractions Versus Spectral Shape

Run the spectral mixture demo in Colab

View the notebook as slides

Recover known fractions, then dim a reference spectrum. Which result changes: its brightness, its spectral angle, or its material fractions?

Check Your Interpretation

A pixel has a small spectral angle to a vegetation reference, but its estimated vegetation fraction is low.

- Are these results necessarily contradictory?
- Which assumptions differ between angle matching and unmixing?
- What evidence would you inspect before naming the material?